



Trial by turn: A spin-friendly Chepauk sets the stage for Afghanistan's Rashid Khan-led attack to test New Zealand in a pivotal Group D clash.

M. VEDHAN

RIVALRIES, RECKONINGS AND RUN-INS

Before the knockouts arrive, a few group games will quietly decide who bends the tournament, and who is broken by it. Here's our pick.

By Dhruva Prasad

>> Afghanistan vs New Zealand, Chennai

Playing New Zealand in spin-friendly conditions at Chepauk will be Afghanistan's golden opportunity to stake a claim for a Super Eight spot from Group D. With skipper Rashid Khan, and mystery spinners Mujeeb Ur Rahman and Noor Ahmad in the ranks, the Afghans boast a formidable trio that can be a handful for the Kiwis. Though they are the more fancied side in the competition, the Kiwis will be mindful of their dramatic collapse against Afghanistan in the last T20 World Cup, when Rashid, Fazalhaq Farooqi and Mohammad Nabi joined forces to skittle them for 75, securing a thumping 84-run win in Providence. However, buoyed by recent Test and ODI series wins in India, the Mitchell Santner-led side will also back its spin unit, which includes Michael Bracewell and Ish Sodhi, to make inroads into an Afghanistan line-up that relies heavily on its top order. While runs are scored at the rate of knots at other venues in India, expect this contest to be a slow burner, where guile and patience trump power.